

WAC play opens

Cats can't afford slip

By STEVE WESTON
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Among University of Arizona's few losses in baseball last season was a 6-4 decision to University of Texas-El Paso's Miners.

It was a major surprise for both teams.

The Wildcats, who went on to a Western Athletic Conference championship and a 58-6 overall record, stormed over the Miners, 25-3, in the first game of a doubleheader on a blustery day at Wildcat Field.

In the seven-inning second game, the Miners pulled the upset.

The current 25-6-1 Cats, not

the awesome powerhouse of a year ago, can't afford that kind of slipup this time around against coach Andy Cohen's 15-9 UTEP squad.

The two teams open WAC play tonight in a 7:30 contest at Hi Corbett Field with right-hander Craig Gioia (4-2, 3.37 earned run average) scheduled to start for UA against UTEP left-hander George Landreth, 3-1 with an 0.85 ERA.

Tomorrow at 1 p.m. at Wildcat Field, UA's Ron Bell (3-1, 5.50), a right-hander, will oppose another UTEP lefty, freshman Ron Wrobel (4-2, 3.46).

UA coach Jerry Kindall

hopes to send out senior right-hander Steve Powers (8-1, 1.85) in the series wrap-up at 7:30 tomorrow night at Hi Corbett. Powers will pitch if he isn't used in relief in the first two games.

Whomever Kindall goes with will hurl against either Jeff Hogan (1-1, 3.93) or Bob Knox (2-0, 2.37), both right-handers, for the Miners.

UA hopes to begin defense of its WAC crown with a three-game sweep. That could be important because No. 1-ranked Arizona State is expected to take three in Tempe against New Mexico.

"If we get three right off it should carry us through,"

commented UA senior center-fielder Dave Stegman.

"We're ready. Our hitting is comparable to last year's team, but we still need to realize ourselves how good we are. Once we do and start playing like we're capable, we have a good shot."

"They (UTEP) look improved," said Kindall of a team which has had uncanny luck on UA's home field. The Cats hold a 32-4 series margin over the Miners, and all four UTEP wins have come in Tucson.

UA's hitting should be the toughest Miner pitchers have yet seen.